

Your parents keep giving advice about decisions that are already yours

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 6 sources · cheatgrid.com

A parent's advice on something you've already settled often signals **warmth**, not doubt about you. A hard stretch in your own life can make ordinary advice land as unwanted.

THE GOAL

You're keeping your own decisions your own. Let them finish, then say plainly that this one is already decided.

CHECKLIST

The moment a parent starts telling you what to do about something you've already decided

- ☐ Let them finish saying it before you respond.
- ☐ Check whether they already know this is decided, or think it's still open.
- ☐ If they don't know, say so plainly: "I've already decided on this."
- ☐ If they do know and keep going anyway, decide now whether this needs a real answer or a short one.
- ☐ For a short one, give a neutral line, like "Thanks, I'll think about it," then move the conversation on yourself.
- ☐ For a real answer, say your decision in **one sentence** and stop there, without listing every reason behind it.
- ☐ If they push back on that one sentence, repeat it once in the same words instead of building a bigger case.
- ☐ After repeating it once, point to something happening right now, like dinner or whatever's next, and move the conversation there.
- ☐ If you feel a pull to do the exact opposite of what they said, **count slowly to ten** before you answer.
- ☐ If a partner or someone else is close by, tell them in a sentence what just happened before you move on.
- ☐ If the exchange is still bothering you afterward, write down the specific thing that's nagging at you, and whether it's part of a pattern.
- ☐ Go back to whatever you were doing before the advice started.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Advice on something already decided can feel like distrust, but it often signals **warmth**, not doubt.
- 2 A hard stretch changes things. It can make ordinary advice from a parent read as unwanted.
- 3 Growing more prickly about their support can be part of becoming your own person.

What their advice is actually telling you

WATCH

Advice on something already decided can feel like distrust, but it often signals **warmth**, not doubt.

People who felt more loved and understood by a parent were the ones who heard from them most, in a weeklong diary study. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Involvement a parent means as support can land on you as control, whatever they intended.

Students who described a more hands-on mother felt less able to run their lives, even though the help was meant to encourage them. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Regular back-and-forth like this is common: plenty of grown adults get exactly this from a parent.

More than a fifth of grown children got several kinds of support, including advice, several times each week, in one large family study. [Source 3](#)

Why it lands differently some days

KNOW

A hard stretch changes things. It can make ordinary advice from a parent read as unwanted.

People coping with something like divorce or a health problem were more likely to call a parent's advice unwanted, a study of adult children found. [Source 4](#)

WATCH

Your parent's own stress about helping can be exactly what makes their tone feel pushier.

A parent's **own stress** and mixed feelings about helping may feed into how conflicted their support feels to a grown child. [Source 5](#)

WATCH

When ordinary advice suddenly reads as unwanted, that's often about friction elsewhere in the relationship, not about them changing.

Children who rated the relationship with a parent more negatively were the ones most likely to call that parent's advice unwanted, in a diary study. [Source 1](#)

What's on you, not on them

WATCH

Growing more prickly about their support can be part of becoming your own person.

Grown children were more likely to see a parent's support as conflicted when they were younger, perhaps during the process of separating from that support. [Source 5](#)

DON'T

The pull to do the exact opposite of advice isn't proof you're thinking for yourself, just a reflex worth sitting with instead of acting on.

People who felt this pull after an unwanted recommendation often ended up choosing the very option it had warned against, across several lab experiments. [Source 6](#)

Sources

1. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8557851/>
2. https://selfdeterminationtheory.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/04/2014_SchiffmanLissEtAl_HelpingOrHoovering.pdf
3. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC4553417/>
4. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6242646/>
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6. https://people.duke.edu/~gavan/bio/GJF_articles/recommendations_mktgsci_04.pdf

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Your parents, now you are grown at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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